‘You can’t have drink unless you eat meal.’

I said we just wanted a quiet drink. She wasn’t having any of it:

‘This is an exclusive restaurant, you know.’

We were getting chucked out. I offered to pay for a full meal if we could just have our drinks but it was too late for that and, suddenly, at eleven o’clock at night, we were standing back out in the street. It was time for Victoria to have her good idea:

‘We could go round to my friend’s house.’

My luck: the friend was Melanie Chisholm. What had I got myself into? I was out with one Spice Girl and now we were going round to another one’s house. How much more nervous could a lad get on a first date?

When we arrived, Melanie was in her pajamas and had got out of bed to answer the door. The moment we walked in, my heart sank. There was this big Liverpool FC poster up on the door. *I’m not ready for this*.

I sat down and Victoria and Melanie went missing for ten minutes. I think they were in the kitchen chatting while I was left on my own on the sofa in the lounge like a complete lemon. By the time they came back, I’d wound myself up all over again. It was like being at a really awkward tea party. Victoria was nervous too, I think. We sat at the two ends of the sofa as if we hadn’t been properly introduced. They chatted. I sat and listened. I’m not sure I actually said a word the whole time we were there.

An hour or two later we were back in Victoria’s MG, continuing our tour of the M25’s beauty spots. I remember she drove us past her parents’ house at one point, maybe just so that I’d know where to find her. Eventually, in the early hours of the morning, we were back at the Castle. The Spice Girls were off to the States the following day and we had to say our goodbyes. I got back in my car and waved. Victoria promised to call when she got to New York. Not exactly the most romantic of first dates, but I felt like it couldn’t have been better. I’d known that all we needed was to meet. Love at first sight? No, it was happening quicker than that.

So was everything else. That 1996/97 season United won the League again and got closer than we ever had before to what I think had become the manager’s real ambition: winning the European Cup again for the club. It’s a bit like learning soccer all over again, getting to grips with playing the best